

"HE HAS RECTITUDE, ABILITY, EFFICIENCY AND FAIRNESS."

Morarji Desai

Jawaharlal Nehru had once written that there are "very few people whom I respect so much for their rectitude, ability, efficiency and fairness as Morarji Desai". Clearly, it was an opinion his daughter shared. She stripped Desai of the Finance Ministry on the grounds he was resisting her radical economic agenda. He had no choice but to quit. A consistent contender for the prime minister's post—he had fought Indira Gandhi in 1967—he finally got his chance in 1977 after the Janata Party rode to power, and became one of the world's oldest heads of state at 81.



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S. NIJALINGAPPA Congress president, on Indira Gandhi

"Tragedy overtakes democracy when a leader who rises to power due to popularity, becomes a political narcissist."

SILENT MADNESS

Khamoshi, directed by Asit Sen, with Waheeda Rehman in the lead, was one of the finest films of the talented actor. With powerful performances by Rajesh Khanna and Nasir Hussein, and Dharmendra in a guest appearance, the film had some disturbing scenes (when Rehman goes insane) and songs that live on (*Woh shaam kuchh ajeeb thi* and *Tum pukar lo*).



BANK ORDER

Indira Gandhi's ordinance nationalising 14 scheduled commercial banks, whose deposits exceeded Rs 50 crore, was invalidated by the Supreme Court a year later, but the Government used a Presidential order to re-nationalise them. In the first six months of nationalisation, 1,100 new branches were opened and loans were given to small-scale entrepreneurs and farmers.

• Nixon suggested an eight-point Vietnam peace plan on May 14, but Xuan Thuy, head of the North Vietnam delegation to the Paris peace talks, rejected his suggestion of mutual withdrawal of troops from South Vietnam.

AP PHOTO

US troops in South Vietnam



• Neil Armstrong became the first man to set foot on the moon, aboard the Apollo-11, the first manned mission to the moon. He was accompanied by Edwin Aldrin.
• Czechoslovakia became a two-nation federation of Czech and Slovak republics.

<< DID YOU KNOW

The Congress Working Committee met in two separate groups for the first time in history, with one group led by Indira Gandhi and the other by S. Nijalingappa.